A Different History

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‘A Different History’

Here is a detailed guide to Sujata Bhatt’s poem 'A Different History' from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Bhatt’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Bhatt’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Bhatt’s intention and message

‘A Different History’ overview

Like many of Sujata Bhatt's poems, ‘A Different History’ examines the idea of diaspora and the conflict between her Indian heritage and life in the English-speaking world. The poem describes traditional Indian values related to Hinduism, and considers the influence of English as a result of British imperialism. She places emphasis on the positive aspects of her own culture and traditions.

‘A Different History’ breakdown

Lines 1–3

> **“Great Pan is not dead;**
> **he simply emigrated**
> **to India.”**

god of the wilderness and fertility, is alive and has moved to India:
    - Pan's death symbolises the end of paganism as Christianity spread
    - The reference to Pan's death alludes to a line written by Greek philosopher Plutarch: "the great god Pan is dead"

Bhatt's intentions

- Bhatt introduces themes of heritage and culture by implying a "Great" god of nature has chosen India which, she suggests, is ironic
    - Bhatt's allusion to mythological figure "Pan" is placed next to the litotes of "simply emigrated" and indented line "to India" to suggest this is unexpected

Lines 4–6

> **"Here, the gods roam freely,**
> **disguised as snakes or monkeys;**
> **every tree is sacred"**

Translation

- The speaker explains why the "Great Pan" has moved to India
- There, the gods are free to wander ("roam") around disguised as animals and trees, because in India nature is respected and considered holy

Bhatt's intentions

- Bhatt highlights aspects of Indian culture that, she says, contrast with the West:
    - She refers to Hindu gods that are in the shape of "snakes" and "monkeys", using imagery that relates to harmony and freedom, like "roam freely"
- Bhatt separates the phrase "every tree is sacred" to highlight the deep respect for nature and equality as an overarching ideology in traditional India

Lines 7–14

> **"and it is a sin**
> **to be rude to a book.**
> **It is a sin to shove a book aside**
> **with your foot,**
> **a sin to slam books down**
> **hard on a table,**
> **a sin to toss one carelessly**
> **across a room."**

books:
    - It is a "sin" to disrespect books or treat them "carelessly"

Bhatt's intentions

- Bhatt uses enjambment and the conjunction "and" to connect books and nature and to show their similar prominence in Indian culture and the Hindu religion:
    - Bhatt emphasises this idea with a list, as if reciting from scripture
- Bhatt's juxtaposition of religious language with informal verbs like "shove" and "toss" blends tradition with modernity, presenting a speaker unconcerned with rules

Lines 15–18

> **"You must learn how to turn the pages gently**
> **without disturbing Sarasvati,**
> **without offending the tree**
> **from whose wood the paper was made."**

Translation

- Bhatt ends the first stanza giving the reader an instruction:
    - It is important to be careful with books as they are made from "sacred" trees
- She explains that damaging a book could "offend" the tree from which it was made, or disturb "Sarasvati" (the Hindu goddess of learning and knowledge)

Bhatt's intentions

- In a direct address, Bhatt presents ancient traditional values as a certainty with the modal verb "must", perhaps suggesting all cultures have strict rules
- Bhatt describes the significance of nature and knowledge within Hinduism:
    - Personification is applied to trees in these lines as it was previously to books: one should not be "rude to a book" nor "offend" a tree

Lines 19–22

> **"Which language**
> **has not been the oppressor's tongue?**
> **Which language**
> **truly meant to murder someone?"**

Translation

- The second stanza begins with the speaker asking two questions:

intend harm ("murder") through the emphasis of "truly"

Bhatt's intentions

- Bhatt's dramatic shift in focus presents the connection between, and the influence of, language and imperialism as she interrogates language and violence
- The repeated questions highlight "oppressor's tongue" and "murder" which introduces darker ideas regarding colonialism

Lines 23–29

> **"And how does it happen**
> **that after the torture,**
> **after the soul has been cropped**
> **with a long scythe swooping out**
> **of the conqueror's face –**
> **the unborn grandchildren**
> **grow to love that strange language."**

Translation

- The final lines are one long sentence: it considers how the "strange" English language could be so loved by India's "unborn grandchildren"
- The line reflects on "torture" inflicted by the "conqueror's face" (Imperial Britain):
  - It describes how natives experienced violence: a "long scythe" refers to tools which, Bhatt says, "cropped" or 'cut' down the Indian identity

Bhatt's intentions

- A seven line sentence conveys Bhatt's overwhelming frustration with India's continued love for English, a language which once suppressed her native country:
  - Bhatt connotes to violent imperialism by describing a powerful "conqueror"
- Bhatt ends the poem as she begins it, with bitter irony: "And how does it happen"
- The sentence is phrased as a question, but posed as a statement to imply an irreversible, yet "strange", truth:
  - Language can be used to oppress, but it is not responsible in itself, and this is why India's "unborn" generations continue to love it

Examiner Tips and Tricks

A good start to writing a "personal and evaluative engagement" is to engage with the key words of the question

- Writing lengthy introductions with biographical or historical facts that are unrelated to the question or linked to writer's purpose "delays" your answer
- Writing about themes not directly related to the question limits your overall grade
- Starting with a list of the devices used by the poet is not "productive"

In other words, your introduction should set up a clear argument that focuses on the writer's purposes and, of course, engages with the specific question asked.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

The exam question requires you to **focus on the deeper ideas in the poem** so, instead of simply identifying techniques or translating quotes, **explore how** the **poet's decisions** reveal a **theme**. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Bhatt's intentions in terms of her choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Bhatt's free verse form follows an irregular rhythm to present a thoughtful, yet irreverent speaker who debates the power of language and its part in the suppression of cultural identity.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The poem lacks rhyme or consistent rhythm, but it uses assonance ("freely" and "monkeys") and sibilance ("disturbing Sarasvati") to create a lyrical quality	Bhatt evokes a sense of harmony in parts of the poem that deal with Hindu and Indian values relating to humans, nature and books
Individual identity	However, this changes when lines are irregularly indented to present a flippant speaker, such as in lines 1–3	Bhatt alters the speaker's tone to sardonically interrogate the power of language to oppress

between narrative perspective, and the poet varies the tones of voice to create an unpredictable reflection on cultural identity and challenge accepted ideas.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The poem's stanzas develop different ideas: initially, a calm speaker describes classical and Indian culture and religion, but stanza 2 introduces a second person voice that bitterly questions the reader	Bhatt's poem refers to mythology, Hinduism, and post-colonial attitudes in a rambling, irregular poem that conveys cultural tensions and contrasts
	The poet uses parallelism to give the speaker's language a thoughtful pace. For example, the repetition of "it is a sin"	This evokes a stern warning to the reader to emphasise the power of respecting a culture and its traditions

Language

Bhatt's poem employs classical allusion and informal language to present cultural tensions, especially between the past and the future. Alongside this, persuasive language presents an argument about the power of language.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem employs anaphora in "it is a sin" to highlight religious language, as well as in "Which language" which questions the violence of a "conqueror's face" who cuts down metaphorical 'souls' with a "swooping" "scythe"	Bhatt uses persuasive language to debate the impact of language in religion, as well as in forms of oppression such British colonialism
Cultural identity	Bhatt juxtaposes classical and traditional allusion with informal verbs like "shove" and "toss"	Bhatt presents themes of history and modernity by embedding ancient references and metaphor in a contemporary debate on the English language and its popularity with India's

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that it is **not enough** just to **know the poem**, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events** to explore the **writer's intentions and methods**. This section has been divided into two main themes that Bhatt explores in 'A Different History':

- Cultural identity
- Individual identity

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward answers that respond "sensitively and in considerable detail" to the way the writer achieves their effects. You are being asked to explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. While knowing about the Hindu religion or British colonisation of India will help you understand debates Bhatt raises, your points should be closely linked to the themes in the poem and relevant to the focus of the question.

Cultural identity

- Sujata Bhatt was born in Gujarat, India, in 1956, and moved to America with her family in 1968, which is perhaps why she calls her poetry "Indian-English":
  - 'A Different History' highlights her native culture by referring to Hindu gods, and the respect and harmony between humans and nature
  - She mentions "Sarasvati" and, by implication, Hanuman, monkey god of wisdom, and snakes that may belong to gods Shiva and Vishnu
  - But, alongside this, she uses informal English like "toss" and "shove"

Individual identity

- India became a colony under British rule in the nineteenth century, amidst much turmoil
- In 'A Different History', the English language is described as the "oppressor's tongue", alluding to its continued prominence in India:
  - Bhatt describes successive generations speaking English in the final lines that mention "unborn grandchildren" who love the "strange" language

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

suggesting that Bhatt's work has a deep connection to her roots
    - The poem considers the way English is used to suppress and overpower, and wonders at the love for it, but concludes that language itself is not to blame

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

"Cambridge IGCSE (9–1) 0992 Literature in English syllabus for examination in 2026." Cambridge International Education, https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/697264-2026-syllabus.pdf. Accessed 6 August 2025.

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